

ORIGINAL ARTICLE

What do recently housed young people imagine for the future of third places? Using game-based inquiry to (re)imagine affirming, youth-centered third places

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Abstract

Third places—public and community settings like parks and libraries—are theorized to serve as sources of social connection, community, and play. Yet, young people who hold marginalized identities, such as those experiencing homelessness and housing instability, often endure discrimination in third place settings. This study used game-based inquiry to partner with recently housed young people who have experienced chronic housing instability ($N = 21$) to understand how they would (re)imagine future third places. We then analyzed transcripts from these game sessions through qualitative thematic analysis. Participants suggested that certain tenets must be present in third places: they must offer opportunities for *agency and individualization*; they must *meet everyday needs*; and they must be *explicitly inclusive*. To actualize these tenets, participants imagined *places that meet many needs and do many things; portable and adaptable physical spaces; freedom to choose how to play; attending to and subverting oppressive social hierarchies; providing choice for privacy or connection; knowing people will be around; and free amenities*. These findings have implications for theoretical development, practices in present and future third places, and methodological development of games in research.

KEYWORDS

foresight, game-based inquiry, housing and homelessness, third places, youth

Highlights

- Young people who hold marginalized identities often endure discrimination in third place settings.
- Game-based inquiry is a novel way to engage young people in reimagining future third places.
- Reimagined third places promote agency, meet everyday needs, and are explicitly inclusive.
- These findings challenge prior theoretical work on third places when considering youth.
- Current and future third places may embrace these tenets to build inclusive third places for youth.

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INTRODUCTION

Approximately 3.5 million young people in the United States experience homelessness and housing instability (Morton et al., 2017); this includes young people who are “couch surfing” or temporarily “doubling up” with others, sleeping in shelters or other institutional settings, and those sleeping outside. Many of these young people have been kicked out of places which have failed to support them (e.g., home, school); others have made decisions to leave these places due to jeopardized safety (Choi et al., 2015; Keeshin & Campbell, 2011). Young people who endure additional axes of marginality and system involvement are overrepresented among unhoused and unstably housed young people, including young people who identify as lesbian, gay, bisexual, transgender, and/or queer (LGBTQ), young people of color, and those with histories of foster care and/or juvenile justice system involvement (Aceves et al., 2020; Britton & Pilnik, 2018; Dworsky et al., 2019; Maccio & Ferguson, 2016; Morton et al., 2018, 2019).

Young people with histories of housing instability further face the impacts of adultism (prejudice against youth), lack of choice, and limited social and political power (Camino & Zeldin, 2002; DeJong & Love, 2015). Yet—amidst such marginalization and oppression—such young people find ways to get their physical and psychological needs met, including seeking places of safety and comfort. Case and Hunter (2012) coined the term *adaptive responding* to refer to the “capacity to circumvent, resist, counteract, and/or mitigate the psychological consequences of oppression” (p. 259). Finding communities and settings that allow young people to be themselves, connect with others, and participate in building new worlds can upend and buffer against impacts of oppressive social structures. Recognizing the limitations of family/home and school settings in meeting young people's needs, *third places* (community settings like parks and libraries; Oldenburg & Brissett, 1982) are a particularly important site for unhoused and unstably housed young people to meet their needs.

Such adaptation requires creativity. One under-discussed—yet vital—aspect of the youth (and human) experience is *play*. While play is a foundational human right, as well as a tool to build meaningful opportunities for young people's participation in civic and social spheres (United Nations, 1989; Wright, 2018), many unhoused and recently housed young people have been robbed of opportunities to play due to the need to focus on survival and meeting everyday needs. Meanwhile, play may be seen as a domain where pre-existing normal patterns of power may temporarily suspend (Hart, 2008), opening a portal, of sorts, into envisioning new ways of being. Recognizing the vital nature of play as a *right* and a *portal*, this study uses game-based inquiry to partner with recently housed young people to understand how

they would (re)imagine third place settings to meet their physical and relational needs.

Third places

Oldenburg and Brissett (1982) coined the term “third places” to refer to places outside of home (“first place”) and work/school (“second place”). In his book *The Great Good Place*, (1999) Oldenburg outlines eight characteristics commonly held among third places: (1) They are “neutral” places that no one owns; (2) Social hierarchies outside of third places are nonexistent within them; (3) They enable socialization; conversation is often the main activity; (4) They are accessible and accommodating; (5) There are “regulars” among those who visit; (6) They maintain a low-profile in appearance (no ostentatious architecture); (7) They offer a playful atmosphere; (8) They provide psychological comfort and emotional support.

Examples of common third places include parks, community centers, recreational settings, cafes, libraries, and religious institutions. In his book *Bowling Alone*, Putnam (2000) warned about the decline of community spaces where people build social capital and connections in contemporary American society. Finlay et al.'s (2019) work confirms that the overall number of third places is declining in American society; third places that experienced the most closures were commercial and personal settings, like barbershops, laundromats, bookstores, and music stores. However, certain third places—like libraries and civic/social organizations—have experienced a net *increase* during this time (Finlay et al., 2019), suggesting that public and community (vs. commercial) third places may be essential to meet the needs of all community members in our present social landscape.

Third places such as community centers have been found to offset the impacts of community health and death rates amidst disasters such as heat waves, wherein communities who had access to such settings fared better in natural disasters even when controlling for other social demographics such as race and socioeconomic status (Klinenberg, 2018). Recent work has also suggested that third places may play an essential role in supporting migrants in accessing resources and connections when adjusting to new communities (Zhuang & Lok, 2023). As such, when third places close, such losses may be most felt among socially and economically marginalized community members, who have come to rely on third places as buffers against stress, isolation, and loneliness, as well as for access to basic resources (Finlay & Kobayashi, 2018; Finlay et al., 2019).

Less empirical attention has been given to participants' experiences in third places and/or the associations between participation in third places and specific social or emotional outcomes. However, research in the last decade has recognized that such experiences are likely to

differ by social location. Hickman (2013) found that several barriers hindered low-income UK residents from participating in third places such as community centers: some residents felt the spaces were inaccessible, and some experienced feeling “unwelcome” among regulars. Not only do these experiences negate Oldenburg's eight characteristics of third places, but they also call into question the capacity of third places to meaningfully welcome individuals who experience social marginalization, as with the low-income residents in the UK neighborhood in Hickman's study. Oldenburg and Brissett (1982) themselves acknowledge that their theory of third places may most aptly apply to “middle class” individuals (p. 270)—let alone those who are further marginalized in society.

Third places for unhoused and recently housed young people

Young people who experience social marginalization—and perhaps *particularly* unhoused young people—often experience intersecting discrimination in public settings; yet they also hold a desire to make such spaces more supportive and welcoming (Irazábal & Huerta, 2016). Emerging evaluative and conceptual work suggests that public libraries may be a particularly ripe third space for young people who experience social marginalization to socialize with others from diverse backgrounds (Lin et al., 2015), meet friends (Bourke, 2010), and accrue social capital (Frey and Codispoti, 2010). Further, work by Townley et al. (2016) has found that young people with experiences of homelessness spend much of their time in service-related spaces (e.g., homeless service centers, health and mental health service agencies). Higher levels of engagement in these settings were associated with better wellbeing. Together, this work suggests the particular importance of third places for young people who have experienced homelessness and housing instability.

Numerous policies and practices dictate “appropriate” ways to spend time in public and community third place settings, including anti-loitering policies, camping bans, and “hostile” or “defensive” architecture; these policies and practices are particularly targeted at unhoused and unstably housed members of our society. Hostile architecture (architecture which obstructs one's ability to comfortably spend time in public settings) prevents unhoused and unstably housed young people from being and feeling welcome in many third places (Aichinger, 2009; McFadden, 2020; Smith & Walters, 2018). This architecture sends both implicit and explicit messages about who is (un)welcome in public space, and how (not) to use public space—especially for those who are unhoused. However, third places may also be sites of social policing for young people who experience social marginalization (Littman, 2021)—

efforts to “look out for” neighbors through informal social control “slip” easily into scornful looks, calls to police, and, in the absolute worst cases, death (see: the murder of Tamir Rice in a public park by the Cleveland Police; Stone & Socia, 2019). Given these realities, we need both third places which welcome and affirm young people in them, as well as shift towards public imagination of who is allowed to spend time in third places.

Considerable work has focused on first places for young people (see, e.g., the Housing First movement [Padgett et al., 2016]) or unhoused young peoples' support needs in second places such as school (Hatchimonji et al., 2021). Considerably less work has explored young peoples' needs and experiences in third places, even though they are spaces young people spend a high proportion of their time. Newly housed young people are a particularly knowledgeable—group to learn from when seeking to create affirming common spaces. For unhoused and unstably housed young people, places that are socially considered third places (such as parks) have often been experienced as first places, or spaces in which young people may have lived, labored, and gathered (Littman, 2020). This paper collects (and creates) knowledge about third places from a group of young people who have a unique vantage point and can thus meaningfully contribute to our collective understanding of what would make third places most supportive.

Foresight practices & game-based inquiry

Foresight - or futures - lenses offer an opportunity to “pre-experience different futures” (Dunagan, personal communication, 2021) which may shape our world. In considering what *might* happen, we can better prepare for—and shape—what *does* happen. Foresight lenses and practices range across histories and disciplines. Lineages include (but are certainly not limited to) the world-shaping power of Afrofuturism and Black speculative fiction (Dery, 1994; Eshun, 2003; Morris, 2012), Indigenous futurism which transcends past/future binaries (Dillon, 2012), queer futurism - which insists on the potentiality of another, better, world which shakes loose the pragmatism of the present (Muñoz, 2019). Our study draws upon lineages of experiential and participatory futures practice (Candy & Kornet, 2019; Ramos et al., 2019), which uses creative practices to increase engagement in explicit efforts to shape more democratic and equitable futures. Threading through these lenses is the imperative of shaping present inequities into future liberation.

According to futures studies scholar Sohail Inayatullah, “the future has always been entangled with gaming,” in the sense that we often inhabit and (re) imagine new worlds (preferred, feared, or otherwise) through games (Inayatullah, 2017, p. 102). Foresight

studies and participatory game design are well-established as complementary approaches to engaging participants in designing more equitable futures (De Vids, 2023; Kantola et al., 2013). The use of card and board games is particularly common within foresight-based games; a well-known example is futurist Stuart Candy's *Thing from the Future* game (Candy, 2018), wherein players are tasked with crafting thought provoking future scenarios using cards which prompt for objects, moods, terrains (social spheres), and arcs (growth, transformation, collapse, constraint).

The *Future of Third Places* game, developed and employed for the first time in this study, draws upon the practice of board and card games in foresight research and practice to partner with recently housed young people to imagine the future of affirming third places. Using a game-based interview approach has been found to support engagement and participation of young people (To et al., 2016) and has untapped potential for more widespread use. As such, this study integrates a well-established approach (game design and foresight studies) to explore a new application (partnering with young people to reimagine future third places)—thereby inviting a commonly marginalized group into collectively reimagining new ways of being.

Present study

While third places are an important space for young people to gather and connect, they are also experienced sites of discrimination, oppression, and exclusion—especially for youth who hold marginalized identities. As such, we need to understand how to create third places that embrace youth-affirming principles and practices. Harnessing the value of youth wisdom in shaping more equitable futures, the present study uses a foresight perspective and game-based inquiry to understand how recently housed young people would create third place settings to meet their emotional and instrumental needs. Specifically, we consider: *How would recently housed young people (re)imagine third place settings to best support their physical, emotional, and relational needs?*

Oldenburg and Brissett's original theoretical conceptualizations of third places are limited in capturing the socio-political power dynamics of present-day society. Recognizing the need to further update theoretical conceptualizations of third places, our study further considers: *how do these (re)imagined third place settings align with, and diverge from, Oldenburg and Brissett's (1982) conceptualization of third places?*

Findings from this study will further conceptual work on third places and offer practical implications for practitioners seeking to create supportive community spaces for young people who have experienced housing

instability, which is an experience often accompanied by additional axes of marginalization.

METHODS

Community partner context and sample

The community partners in this study include residents at Laurel House Apartments (LH), a 34-unit permanent supportive housing (PSH) program for young adults in Grand Junction, CO. Grand Junction is a city in Western Colorado within an otherwise rural mountain region. Grand Junction, a city of about 66,000 people, is nearly 90% white and has a median household income of \$58,892 as of 2022 (U.S. Census Bureau, 2022). Leaseholders at LH are between the ages of 18–24 at the time of lease signing and are determined eligible for LH based on a high score on the Transition-Age Youth-Vulnerability Index-Service Prioritization Decision Assistance Tool (TAY-VI-SPDAT; Orgode Consulting, 2015). The TAY-VI-SPDAT assesses chronicity of housing instability, physical and mental health functioning, emergency service use, and social relationships.

Residents at LH were ideal partners for piloting game development and engaging in collaborative inquiry about the future of third places based on (a) ongoing relationships via a research partnership with LH staff and residents, and (b) the recognition—from a design justice perspective (Costanza-Chock, 2020)—that future inclusive designs need to prioritize the needs of those most marginalized in society, thus meeting the needs of the whole. Young people who have experienced intersecting oppression such as housing instability, homelessness, mental health and substance use challenges, and chronic failure by our social structures, hold vital wisdom to (re) imagine futures which subvert and transform social structures.

Game development process

Game-based inquiry draws upon the lineage of *serious games*—a term first coined by Abt (1987)—to refer to games which hold a practical purpose (e.g., education, decision-making, discovery). While often used for simulation or education in the military, schools, and workplaces, serious games are increasingly being used for research purposes (Laamarti et al., 2014). In our study, we use an original board game to engage young people in PSH to understand how they would (re)imagine future third place settings. Recognizing that serious games which involve future users in game development are more attuned to users' desires and needs (Fitzgerald & Ratcliffe, 2020) we used a continuous iterative design process (Bromley, 2012) to design the *Future of Third*

Places Game; this process included *brainstorming*, *prototyping*, *implementing*, and *playtesting*.

Brainstorming began with conversations with residents and staff at LH about what makes for engaging games for their community. We learned that, for those who offered feedback, the most enjoyable games for the LH community include an engaging facilitator, a well-told story of the ‘world of the game,’ accessibility (described as easy-to-learn rules), and opportunities to collaborate or work alone to adapt to the relationships of those playing.

The *prototyping* process included workshoping game ideas with three game design experts and two groups of colleagues who focus on creative play and foresight practice (5 hourlong conversations in all). During these conversations, the first author brought in ideas of game mechanics and received feedback during each meeting about how to strengthen the game – this included creating a more compelling story, clearer objectives, and bringing mechanics in from well-known games (e.g., the “judging” mechanic in Apples to Apples) to accomplish game objectives. At this point, “community request cards” were drafted—ideas for these cards were drawn from extensive time spent in informal conversations with residents at LH and extant literature on the ways unhoused and recently housed young people are uniquely marginalized and discriminated against in present third places (e.g., being seen as loitering in coffee shops, being asked to move along if seen resting in parks).

The *implementation* process began with two pilot game play sessions with colleagues to practice facilitation and receive feedback. In these sessions, the first author facilitated full game sessions for groups of 4–6 players, then received feedback about what worked well and what could be strengthened for compelling game play and sustained participation.

Finally, *playtesting* occurred alongside data collection at LH in October 2022. While we will further describe *Future of Third Places Game* in a methodological paper on the topic, we will share the details of the game briefly here:

- The game can be played with 2–8 players.
- The game begins with the facilitator welcoming players into the world 10 years from now where they have been tasked to serve on the design team for a new third place.
- Players fill out (and share) “worldbuilding cards” that imagine the world 10 years from now and “personal expertise cards” which describe the skills they each bring to this design team.
- The “meat” of the game: players take turns reading “community request cards” (e.g., a community member seeks a public place to sit and eat in peace without being stared at, a community member wants a place that feels safe after dark to hang out).

- Using craft supplies, players have 3 min to design a physical or social element that responds to the community request card.
- Players share their designs (facilitators and players ask follow up questions for clarity as needed); the card reader votes on the design that “wins” (based on the metrics of *answering the community request card*, *honoring the world 10 years from now*, and *honoring the expertise of those in the room*).
- Whoever collects the most community request cards (by having their design chosen) “wins” and gets to cut the ribbon on the new community third place.
- Participants were invited to keep one design from the game back with them—something from the game world that they wish existed in their present world.

Data collection

All LH participants were invited to participate in playing the Future of Third Places Game in October 2022 during a multi-day research team visit to LH. The data collection team comprised the first and second author, who were co-investigators on a parent longitudinal study exploring experiences and outcomes associated with moving into permanent supportive housing (PSH) for young adults. While spending time in the lobby of LH, researchers shared about the opportunity to participate in our study and displayed designs which emerged from games throughout the course of the visit. We gave residents the opportunity to ask questions about our study and choose whether to consent. At this time, participants also identified whether they consented to game recording and photography while playing the game.

Data included recorded and transcribed transcripts from game play sessions, where participants described the designs they created in response to the community request cards. The final sample included 21 LH residents over six game sessions. The research team also memoed after each game session to note important group dynamics from each game session.

We intentionally did *not* systematically collect demographic information of game participants. It was important to us, as Co-Investigators of a broader longitudinal study which collected extensive personal information, to create a necessarily different research experience for participants in this game. We know, based on LH program eligibility, that a typical LH leaseholder is between 18 and 24 upon arriving at LH, has experienced at least 1 year of housing instability, and scored highly on a vulnerability index measuring trauma exposure and mental and physical health experiences. Our prior research suggests that LH residents tend to be predominantly white (74%) straight (59%) men (52%) with a high school diploma (56%). Additional information about our sampling frame can be found in Littman et al. (2023).

Game sessions ranged from 54 min to 1 h 34 min in length (average 1 h 14; standard deviation = 14.9) and participants were each paid \$50 (via a grocery store gift card) for participating. The data collection was approved by the University of Denver Institutional Review Board.

Data analysis

The analysis team included the two research team members who facilitated data collection, a PhD student who participated in the game's prototyping sessions, and a masters student who cleaned and analyzed transcriptions.

After transcriptions were cleaned and uploaded into Dedoose qualitative software, we used Oldenburg and Brissett's (1982) tenets of third places as an a priori parent coding scheme to guide thematic analysis (Braun & Clarke, 2012), adapting a couple tenets to be slightly broader to capture a constructivist lens on experiences (e.g., "low profile" became "descriptions of appearance" to capture the many kinds of physical spaces participants created; "neutral places" became "ownership" to capture the various power dynamics of ownership). We added the code, "does not fit into Oldenburg and Brissett's (1982) framework" to capture ideas outside of the original framework.

Our coding process employed a team-based inductive coding approach (Cascio et al., 2019). First, each team member applied the a priori codebook to one transcript, while systematically taking notes on *analytic memos*, *process memos*, and *bias memos*. We then met for 2 hourlong meetings to discuss our memos and review transcripts to build consensus around parent code applications. Using our analysis memos as a guide, we added subcodes to the codebook to describe sub-concepts identified within each parent code; we applied these to the transcript together. We repeated the same process for the second transcript. Then, we broke into two pairs, with each group completing the same process for two of the four remaining transcripts. Any subcodes identified in this final stage were added to the other team's two transcripts. During this last stage of the coding process, our team met for five additional hourlong meetings to discuss codes and memos and build consensus. In these meetings, our discussions often centered around decision points—like, whether to include designs created by our research team members who facilitated the game (no, unless it was a collaborative design with a participant), and how our own biases around present dynamics in third places—such as how measures towards building "safety" often slip into surveillance of young people—shaped our interpretations of participant designs. We continually returned to our data to ground our interpretations in participants words, photographs of designs, and our observation notes as facilitators.

Finally, we met for a longer (3 hour) theming session to explore how our findings aligned with and diverged from Oldenburg and Brissett's (1982) framework. On a large whiteboard, we listed the original eight tenets which guided our codebook. We discussed some of the assumptions implicitly present in Oldenburg and Brissett's original (1982) third places framework—such as the assumption that people have stable "first" and "second" places, and that a social setting in our present world can be neutral given modern-day social construction of power. Then, we discussed alignment and divergence from these tenets as indicated by our subcodes. At this point, we recognized that our data was easily divided into two main categories: the tenets that need to be present in creating affirming third places for young people, and the physical and relational qualities that actualize these tenets. We identified that these themes cut across multiple card prompts from our game deck, suggesting their value in being lifted up as the most important tenets and qualities that shape what we learned about third places from this research.

Research team positionality; credibility & trustworthiness

The social locations of team members undoubtedly impacted our approach to data collection and analysis. The first author is a white, cisgender female PhD-holder who has lived with strong social capital and economic support throughout her life. The second author is a white, femme, queer, master-holder, who has primarily lived in rural settings, with experiences of homelessness as a child and emerging adult. The third author is a white, upper-class, cisgender woman who is currently a master's student and has experienced housing stability throughout her life. The fourth author is a white, queer, nonbinary first-generation PhD student who grew up in the rural southeast of the U.S. While he has never experienced homelessness, family members close to him have (his mom, sister, and grandmother), and he witnessed the impacts of that. The last author is a Black, cisgender, heterosexual married woman who has experienced a high level of housing stability throughout her life. All authors have experience working with youth, often in third places, and most have long-term experience with game-based and/or arts-based work.

These lived experiences and perspectives necessarily inform our approach to this work. Some of our lived experiences align with our partners in this study, and some diverge. Yet, we come to this work with a belief and commitment that better worlds are possible. To enhance credibility and trustworthiness throughout the analytic process, the research team employed *triangulation* via multiple coders, *prolonged engagement*, and *peer debriefing* (Amankwaa, 2016).

TABLE 1 Game session descriptions.

Game Session	Length (minutes)	Number of Participants ($N = 21$)	Researcher notes on dynamics
1	63	5	Participants paired up in teams to accommodate larger group
2	86	3	There was notable care between group members; spirit of collaboration
3	94	4	There was a lot of joking around during this session - two participants knew each other well and two did not.
4	77	6	Participants paired up in teams to accommodate larger group - a staff member joined for this game.
5	68	2	The game felt quiet, intimate with only two participants who knew each other well
6	54	1	This game was run as a solo game by a research team member due to desire not to engage in larger group dynamics

FINDINGS

We provide available participant details of each game in Table 1, including number of participants, game length, and group dynamics of note. In our findings, we report participant quotes by game session (Game 1–6), rather than reported by individual participants, due to the collaborative nature of the game session, and often mutually-constructive nature of the designs created. Games ranged from one to six players; in some of the larger groups, players paired up with one another, which offered an opportunity for collaboration and joint brainstorming for those who found it supportive. Each game was facilitated by one research team member, and the second research team member often joined into game sessions as well to help spark creativity and offer clarity where needed.

In the *Future of Third Places Game*, participants were invited to create designs (out of materials like pipe cleaners, play doh, Legos, blocks, and paper) to respond to “community request cards” from fictional young people (based on young peoples’ lived experiences through prior research and conversations) that outlined the kinds of pain points and desires arising in present-day third places. For example, one card relays a young person’s desire to have a place to sit and eat lunch in a park without feeling stared at like they do not belong. Another card describes a young person who is seeking spaces to gather where they do not have to spend money. One depicts a young person who is seeking a space to rest during the day when they have been sleeping unsheltered and fitfully at night without being seen as loitering.

Our findings illuminated that—unlike prior conceptualizations of third places—certain tenets must be present in creating third place settings for recently housed young people (Table 2). According to participants, third places must offer opportunities for *agency and individualization*, *meet everyday needs*; and be *explicitly inclusive*. Further, based on participants’ insights, we identified several physical and relational

TABLE 2 How recently housed young people would (re)imagine third place settings to meet their needs.

<i>How would recently housed young people (re)imagine third place settings to best support their physical, emotional, and relational needs?</i>	
Tenets which must be present in third places	Agency and individualization Explicit inclusion Meeting everyday needs
Physical and relational qualities which actualize these tenets	Places that meet many needs and do many things Portable & adaptable physical spaces Freedom to choose how to play Choice for privacy or connection Attend to & subvert oppressive social hierarchies Knowing people will be around Free amenities

qualities of third places that may actualize these tenets: *places that meet many needs and do many things; portable and adaptable physical spaces; freedom to choose how to play; attending to and subverting oppressive social hierarchies; providing choice for privacy or connection; knowing people will be around; and free amenities.*

Tenets centered in third places for recently housed young people

Agency and individualization

Participants in the *Future of Third Places Game* imagined settings where agency and individualization were at the core: where those who gather in such settings could

determine how to engage in the space, with no external expectation that one way of engaging was more “right” or “wrong” than another. When narrating the qualities of their designs, participants often described the *agency* involved in spending time in such settings as paramount to their designs—in being able to show up and engage in ways that aligned with current needs and desires (e.g., a community center with many rooms to attend to many different needs). Participants further conjured many descriptions of physical spaces which were malleable and “*individualizable*” to adapt to a community members’ needs and desires. This often included portability (e.g., a mobile community center or portable sleeping space) as well as the ability to change a space to make it one’s own (e.g., walls that open or close to allow for socialization and privacy, a sleeping space with a retractable roof).

Explicit inclusion

Several participants in the *Future of Third Places Game* largely imagined third places as *explicitly inclusive*: they anticipate and meet the needs and desires of those who frequent them and inherently build in inclusive practices and policies. For example, multiple participants recognized that conventional third places like bars and clubs exclude those under 21; one participant shared, “we have a lot of bars here, but no places that people under the age of 21 can go to” (Game 1). Participants recognized the need for third places to explicitly include those who are often excluded from the imagined populace of conventional third place settings.

This aim of explicit inclusion often attended to dynamics beyond practical inclusion and into *relational* inclusion as well. One participant, recognizing the privileging of extroverts in many socially centered third place settings, designed a “safe circle” where “not only extroverts can go, but introverts.” Within this safe circle, there are “calming pods that people can go and sit in... and if they do not want people watching them eating their sandwich they can sit in there” (Game 2). Another participant designed a radically inclusive space—a “safe zone” where “everybody would feel included.” In this safe zone, there were “other spaces for [people] to go to” if they get in a “squabble” or have trouble aligning with the rules of being “kind,” “courteous,” and “friendly” (Game 2). This way, everyone would have a safe place to go, even amidst relational conflict that may emerge.

Meeting everyday needs

Participants imagined places as spaces where community members’ everyday needs could be fulfilled. Often, these needs related to food and sleep—which was likely hard to come by for many participants throughout their lives.

Unlike Oldenburg & Brissett’s conceptualization of third place settings as adjunctive to first and second places, the participants in this study imagined third place settings as places which could fulfill everyday needs that tend to be met by first and second places. Multiple participants created “nap pods” (Game 4) or other places to sleep within third place settings. When discussing what they wanted to bring back from the world of the game to our real world, one participant shared: “I’d bring back the portable house because I know what it’s like to be on the streets... I was homeless for almost 3 years, you know, on the streets and it’s not a fun place” (Game 5). Rather than third places as primarily social environments, participants in the *Future of Third Places Game* imagined them as social and communal environments that also meaningfully met community members’ everyday needs.

Physical and relational qualities that actualize these tenets

Places that meet many needs and do many things

Attending to the tenet of agency and individualization, several groups created singular community spaces which served many purposes. In one game session, a group created a club with many rooms that met varied physical needs and ways of engaging, like a room with a ball pit “if you want to dance” and a room with a couch “when, you know, you just want to sit” (Game 5). In another game, a group created a community center with several choices of what to do—a “free space so people can sit down, enjoy, learn new things,” the opportunity to “go get stuff from the coffee shop to be able to make your own food if you want,” and “crafts, crocheting and stuff... just a little bit of everything for everybody” (Game 2). In these singular spaces, *many* needs and desires were imagined and attended to within the context of future third places.

Portable and adaptable physical spaces

To actualize the tenets of agency and individualization, participants created multifaceted and malleable physical spaces—often through *portability* and *adaptability*. In one game session, a participant created a portable community center to provide geographic accessibility to community members without community centers nearby: “...it doesn’t have a stay in like the one part of say the city but it can move... and everybody knows, hey, the big old Community Center is right there... It’s like a mobile clinic. A mobile community.” (Game 2).

Further, many participants created physical spaces that could, in and of themselves, mold to meet the needs of community members who spent time in them. One

participant created an adaptable shelter space for sleep and meditation that attended to both the desires and needs of the community members *and* the elements: “you have your shelter... say for example, it's raining. You can go underneath here and there's a second, a second story. And there's a bed that flops down. And then, you push that up... And there's a meditation spot.” (Game 5). Another participant created a “sleeping pod with retractable roof” that allowed community members to have a comfortable space to spend time that was private while having the option of fresh air. (Game 3). After historically not having stable or safe places to sleep, recently housed young people described seeking third places that adapt to meet this need to comfortably rest.

Freedom to choose how to play

Further exemplifying the tenets of agency and inclusion, participants created places where people could dance, recreate outdoors, play games, and hold social events. Some places were designed to allow adults and adolescents to play and move in the ways that adults are discouraged from doing (like jumping in ball pits or playing on playgrounds at a park). There were water parks and amusement parks and indoor gaming spaces with video games and board games. Across these spaces, there were multiple activities to choose from; these choices promoted community members' agency and wellbeing. One participant created “a space for young people to have parties and events and hang out with friends where they aren't pressured into liquor—like a bar for people under 21” (Game 4). Another participant in the same game session shared their group's design, which combined a sense of play and calm:

“So, we kind of made, like, an adult park—you know, more for like people who are high schoolers and older because we don't actually have play equipment. But like a place where people can just go to breathe near a body of water” (Game 4).

In these spaces, there was freedom to define play for oneself, and engage in such play as aligned with one's desires and needs.

Choice for privacy or connection

Participants shared their desire for spaces that enable socialization and connection with others—particularly spaces that gave them the option of socializing with others, but where it was not forced or required. One participant designed park benches that sensed when two people desired connection, and automatically slid them closer together: “These are two benches, right?... You

press a button and the two benches kind of like join together... I kinda like the idea of like... they just slide in together” (Game 3). Another participant designed a “hang pod” with the option for privacy or connection:

“So, mine's like a little like, hang pod, where if you're wanting to... it has like a, this is a handle. And with this, you can decide whether you want it to be open or closed. And so, you can like hang and have it open if you do want to be open to the world, but you can have it kind of closed if you want to hang to yourself. You don't want to feel like people are watching you” (Game 1).

Across several designs, participants built in choices of how connected or exposed one is to others in the space.

Finally, participants often invoked a desire for privacy as a place to nap or get away for a while. In addition to “nap pods” that allow for comfort and privacy (Game 4), one participant described a teepee that an imagined young person could make out of found materials:

“You know, like, she's just gathers what she has... to make it. But this, you know, she found a park and she found a pile of dirt. And she from just the stuff she's collected and stuff like that she's made a cushion and stuff like that. And then she just found a safe spot that like was away from people but still in town. And like that was just a space for her to like go sleep and stuff” (Game 5).

These designs all share a thread of *agency* around the choice for connection, and physical spaces that mold to *actualize* one's agency.

Attend to & subvert oppressive social hierarchies

Participants designed spaces to attend to and subvert oppressive social hierarchies (e.g., classism, ageism, and ableism) through the future third places they built. When designing places for young people, participants sometimes included adults in the environment in ways that intentionally shift conventional social hierarchies and meet needs. In one game, a participant designed “a drop-in center for young people. There are adults present, but they aren't necessarily in charge” (Game 3). In other designs, the role of the adults was to provide mentorship, resources, or comfort, especially when that was lacking in other spaces in their lives:

“The parents aren't allowed to be you know, bossy like... they don't tell you what to do.

It's more for like that comfort. Yeah, it's more of like if you've lost your... your mother or father as a child. And you know, they're there to be that father figure or mother figure for you" (Game 5).

Further, several participants recognized that attending to and subverting entrenched social hierarchies does not just "happen"—it often entails building intentional community care norms that those who frequent these third places agree to follow. One participant created a "self-sufficient community...building" with private sleeping pods, as well as the norm that "when they're done, they clean up after themselves and take care of the thing... they have to wash [the sheets] themselves and they're still, like, taking care of our community" (Game 4). In these spaces, conventional social hierarchies were subverted through collective community care.

Knowing people will be around

Some participants described safety as someone always being around, and/or someone always being there to check in on you if you need it. Oftentimes, this meant that spaces were always open (as one participant described, open "25/8" [Game 5]). One participant described how their design was not unlike a mental health center where they had spent time; they felt safe in this space because they always knew someone would be around:

Participant: "Mine is based off of mental hospitals because I personally like mental hospitals.... if you're feeling suicidal, like, and you just need someone to talk to, there's always someone there. And like you can do groups, like in a mental hospital, and there's a cafeteria, so you can eat there too, and just get the help you need."

Facilitator: "What are the hours of this space?"

Participant: "I would say 24/7. Because there are times where people really need help. And there's nobody around." (Game 2)

A few participants sought a sense of safety through knowing that someone was always watching (e.g., through cameras) even if people were not physically there. In one design, a participant described how cameras could allow Murphy, the fictional community member who "wrote" the request card, to feel safer:

"It's got cameras everywhere so everybody can feel safe.... It's like a safe spot. A safe

house.... like Murphy was saying that things have happened to him before and that's something I looked into, so I -- there's cameras everywhere. No one's gonna want to do anything bad." (Game 5)

Similarly, another participant in the same game session created a monitoring mechanism watching over a community dance hall: "there's the eye of the sky of the whole building and they're making sure you know everyone's still safe and good." (Game 5). The sense that someone is always "around" was an important way of actualizing a sense of safety, comfort, and support throughout multiple game sessions.

Free amenities

Participants described a variety of free spaces they would want, including free access to sober community spaces for those who are abstaining or recovering from substance use (Game 2), free food (Game 4), camping sites (Game 5), a place to play indoor games, such as foosball and air hockey (Game 4), and a playground/amusement park with a water park for community members to enjoy (Game 3). One participant shared:

"Essentially what I think of when I think of that is like a community center. And you don't have to pay, you don't have to get a membership. It's not like a rec center.... And then there's like outside like dining spaces that they can go and sit, eat, chat with their friends, you know, they don't have to be enclosed all the time" (Game 2).

Participants also imagined alternative economies in third places where community members could exchange items they brought for goods the space provided. One group added a coffee shop where "...the way to get a coffee is you have to bring canned food or food that you don't want. And then you get a ticket... and you can get like a snack or coffee or something like that." (Game 4). Across many designs and multiple games, free amenities and alternative economies were a vital means to actualize the tenet of meeting community members' everyday needs.

DISCUSSION

Recognizing that our world oppresses and marginalizes those who fall outside of the white-middle class-adult-cis-hetero-patriarchy, we partnered with recently housed young people to better understand what they seek in and imagine for third places. To intentionally subvert the impacts of marginalization and oppression, participants

suggest that third places need to allow for *agency and individualization*. They need to be *explicitly inclusive* rather than assuming that neutrality will lead to inclusion. To attend to the numerous needs unmet by first and second places for many, they also need to *meet everyday needs* (e.g., food and shelter). After (often, many years of) adaptively responding to the world that has failed to meet their needs, recently housed young people are looking for a place that is adaptable on their terms, and as their needs and conditions shift.

Yet, it is not enough to hold these tenets in mind; they need to be intentionally actualized, or existing power structures may reify oppression and marginalization inherent in our society. Whereas Oldenburg and Brissett (1982) suggest that third places can, by virtue of their public and open nature, mitigate social hierarchies, participants in our study recognize that social hierarchies must be actively subverted through intentionally anti-oppressive interactions. Whereas Oldenburg and Brissett imagine that socialization is the main activity in third places, and that such socialization offers a sense of “play” otherwise unavailable to us, participants in our study elevate the need for agency—to socialize or be alone, and to *choose* how to play. While Oldenburg and Brissett see third places as implicitly providing psychological comfort and emotional support, study participants suggest that explicitly knowing people will be around is—in and of itself—a valuable source of support. Further, having the option to connect with adults who act explicitly differently from parents, teachers, or other adults who have used power to harm—is one means of subverting oppressive social hierarchies replete in broader society. Finally, while Oldenburg and Brissett see third places as necessarily accessible and accommodating, participants in our study offer specifics to help actualize this tenet. When seeking to be accessible and accommodating to unhoused and recently housed young people, third places must aim to meet everyday needs and provide amenities, such as always being open, being free, and offering food and comfortable places. Further, places should thus meet many needs and do many things, including portability and adaptable physical qualities.

Our work thus offers an expansion and grounding of Oldenburg and Brissett's (1982) in the conditions of our present social milieu. Our findings, when placed in conversation with contemporary third place scholars, elevate the need for third places to serve as sites which bolster the physical and mental health of those most marginalized in our society—such as those enduring climate-related crises like heat waves (Klinenberg, 2018), migrants adjusting to new communities (Zhuang & Lok, 2023), and those in need of basic resources and vital social connection (Finlay & Kobayashi, 2018; Finlay et al., 2019).

Among young people who have experienced homelessness and housing instability, third places such as libraries, community centers, and homeless service

programs may be a particularly valuable site for meeting emotional and physical needs—especially given the gaps created by the limitations of first and second places in meeting young peoples' needs. Though prior work has documented the importance of these spaces among this group of young people (Bourke, 2010; Frey and Codispoti, 2010; Lin et al., 2015; Townley et al., 2016), our work offers clarity on *how* such places can best support young people. Third places that aim to support young people who have experienced homelessness and housing instability must be explicitly inclusive, meet everyday needs, and offer agency and individualization.

Implications for policy and practice

Participants in our study recognize that third places are vital sources of connection for community members, while also helping to meet their everyday needs. Many third places in our society already exist in this way and/or have historically done so. For example, public libraries in the United States have long served as refuges for individuals experiencing housing instability (Bausman, 2016); public parks began as pseudo-social service providers in early 1900s cities amidst the rise of industrialization (Chiesura, 2004). In recent decades, libraries have continued to innovate to meet patrons' psychosocial and everyday needs, often placing social workers and counselors on library staff, and stocking hygiene items, snacks, and warm items for those who seek them (Provence, 2018; Wahler et al., 2020). Scholars have even called for libraries to be seen as a vital part of the community health ecosystem (Philbin et al., 2019). Yet, third places like parks and libraries are generally funded through local government funds or taxes, and are thus privy to budget cuts in times of crises or reprioritization (Matthews, 2020). Our findings remind us of the importance of advocating for funding protection—and expansion—for these third places as sites of vitality and connection to people and resources.

Yet, protecting and uplifting such spaces does not guarantee that they will meaningfully meet the resource and relational needs of those who frequent them. If left to social forces, such settings may revert to reifying the oppressive forces rampant in broader society. As such, third place settings for unhoused and recently housed young people must build intentional practices to subvert social oppression and meet young people's needs and desires. The physical and relational qualities described by participants in our study act as a valuable guide for building intentional practices. See Table 3 for suggestions for practitioners in creating and supporting unhoused and recently housed young people in third places like parks, libraries, community centers, and after-school programs.

Simply making such implications a reality, however, will not be sufficient in shifting social realities in third

TABLE 3 Suggestions for practitioners in third places for unhoused and recently housed young people (libraries, parks, community centers, after-school programs, etc.).

Qualities of third places	Suggestions for practitioners
Places that meet many needs and do many things	Create community-center-type spaces which have many sub-sections and purposes (e.g., places to sit, dance, connect or meet, gather in large groups, rest alone).
Portable & adaptable physical spaces	Have mobile/pop up versions of larger third places; Prioritize furniture or other infrastructure which is modular to adapt to user needs (e.g., sitting alone, meeting with others).
Freedom to choose how to play	Places which honor and provide multiple kinds of play (e.g., board and video games, sports, art, dancing, crafts).
Attend to & subvert oppressive social hierarchies	Mentorship opportunities where adults support young people in youth-determined ways; social norms which flatten hierarchies (sign-up sheets that allow all community members access to the same resources; calendars which celebrate everyone's birthdays).
Choice for privacy or connection	Places to be alone or to gather; places that allow for adaptability between being alone and gathering.
Knowing people will be around	Places that are open 24/7 or for extended hours to allow connection and care outside of the 9am–5pm norm.
Free amenities	Free food, free resources (e.g., books, games, etc.); Barter systems which allow folks to trade items for other resources.

places. A vital part of realizing the kind of youth-affirming third places described in this study will necessarily include significant shifts to public consciousness and perception about who is allowed to spend time in third places, and how they are allowed to spend time. Unfortunately, neighborhoods with high rates of youth involvement in criminalized activities may be particularly unfriendly to efforts which promote youth gathering in public spaces. Such gathering may be perceived as negative “loitering” rather than prosocial participation in public life. As such, such efforts towards shifting third places are likely to be most successful if paired with explicit messaging about the promising relationship between youth activity participation on positive well-being outcomes (see, e.g., Gearhart & Littman, 2024).

Methodological implications for community planning processes

In this study, we piloted the Future of Third Places Game as an inquiry tool for understanding how recently young people would redesign future third places to meet their needs. In doing so, we focused on imaginary futures as not to promise or suggest that specific changes would come from this process. After initial piloting, we suggest that the game may also serve as a valuable community planning tool for organizations or planners interested in capturing community feedback in future design processes. For example, an organization who already serves as a third place—such as a library—could use this game to include stakeholders in imagining adaptations to the setting that could better meet community members’ needs. This would require (a) playing the game, then (b) translating the imagined creations into practical applications. Further, a community organization or

planner who is seeking to create a new third place—such as a new park—could use the game as a brainstorming tool to include community members in design decisions from the outset.

Limitations & directions for future research

While our study offers novel theoretical and empirical insight into the future of third places, certain limitations should be noted. Our sample size ($N = 21$) is apt for capturing the in-depth experiences of young people who have been recently housed (after chronic housing instability) in Western Colorado, albeit necessarily limited in representing experiences of those who differ from our sample. Future research should explore how these adapted third place tenets map onto—or shift—when applied to young people in other geographic locations (e.g., more metropolitan environments) and who hold other marginalized and oppressed identities (e.g., who identify as LGBTQ, people of color, and/or disabled). Future research should test these tenets through both qualitative inquiry—game sessions with identity affinity groups—and later through quantitative survey methods to explore broader empirical applications when seeking to create affirming third place settings for young people who hold specific marginalized and oppressed identities.

Our data collection approach—which did not include collecting individualized demographic information, is limited in capturing the unique intersectional experiences of specific participants. While we felt this approach of centering *connection* and *play* over demographic specificity allowed for particularly deep engagement with participants through data collection, we are unable to ascertain the extent to which certain demographic and/or

experiential characteristics (e.g., employment status and time available, mental health and substance use experience, social identities and how those do/do not relate to our research team members) shaped participation. Future research should consider these tradeoffs of engagement and demographic specificity when planning data collection, which may include integrating demographic and experiential characteristics into game play through “character development.”

Further, it is important to consider our findings within the iterative and participatory context of our game design process. Because community request cards were developed based on, and tailored to, perspectives of young people who have experienced homelessness spending time in third places—both from prior literature and conversations at LH—certain findings may be elevated beyond what would have inductively emerged if we had used other (e.g., non-game-based) methodologies. For example, young people at LH had described (during interviews and surveys for our parent study) needing places to safely and comfortably rest in third places. Further, prior literature suggests unhoused and unstably housed people are discriminated against in public and community third place settings through practices like anti-loitering laws and hostile architecture (Aichinger, 2009; Smith & Walters, 2018). We therefore created a card which describes how a community member is seeking a place to comfortably rest, especially when they have trouble sleeping at night. Thus, designs for this round focused on creating places which met this community member's need for rest, comfort, and perceived safety. One participant—whose prior interactions with the first author in fact contributed to *designing* this card—remarked that they related to the (fictional) person who wrote the card when it was read during the game. While the community request cards were created to illustrate relevant experiences and needs for participants (and seemed to succeed in doing so), certain findings may be overstated based on this iterative design process. Future game development should thus seek to create game cards that capture nuanced experiences and needs of community partners and community members. Further, the game may be adapted and tailored to lived experiences of different groups and thus help to (re)imagine new third places tailored to meet their desires and needs. Further adaptation and collaborative development of the game may also make space for game players to explore less “prosocial” engagement in third places (i.e., what is/should be the role of activities such as substance use in these spaces?), which may have been understated in these findings based on our limited game cards and developing relationships with participants.

Conclusion

Third places are a promising imaginary—and potential source of connection and vitality—in past, present, and

future society. Recognizing the limitations of Oldenburg and Brissett's (1982) conceptualization of third places in attending to social realities for recently housed young people, we used game-based inquiry to understand how recently housed young people would (re)imagine future third places. Participants suggested that certain tenets must be present in third places: they must offer opportunities for *agency and individualization*; they must *meet everyday needs*; and they must be *explicitly inclusive*. To actualize these tenets, participants imagined *places that meet many needs and do many things*; *portable and adaptable physical spaces*; *freedom to choose how to play*; *attending to and subverting oppressive social hierarchies*; *providing choice for privacy or connection*; *knowing people will be around*; and *free amenities*. These findings have implications for theoretical development, as well as practical implications for present and future third place settings who aim to adapt practices to better serve young people. Finally, future third place settings may consider design processes which employ game-based inquiry to partner with young people to meaningfully center their needs, desires, and imaginations.

CONFLICT OF INTEREST STATEMENT

The authors declare no conflict of interest.

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